University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

8,373: Geopolitics and International Security

ECTS credits: 4

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (35%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Active participation, Analog, Individual work individual grade (25%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (40%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,373,1.00 Geopolitics and International Security -- English -- Toft Monica

Course information

Prerequisites

No formal requirements but students are expected to have a basic familiarity with international relations theory and a general understanding of global security issues. An interest in geopolitics, conflict, and security policy is strongly recommended. Students have to read at least the mandatory literature and come to class prepared.

Learning objectives

By the end of this course students will be able to:

- **Apply major IR theories and core concepts** (power, polarity, deterrence, sovereignty) to explain conflict, cooperation, and security dynamics.
- **Analyze the causes, escalation, and termination of war** across interstate, civil, irregular, and nuclear contexts.
- **Evaluate strategic tools and policy options** (diplomatic, military, economic, informational) for managing security threats and crises.
- **Assess emerging security challenges** including climate change, and the role of gender in conflict.
- **Trace the evolution of the international system** from Westphalian structures to contemporary contested geopolitical orders.
- **Apply theory to real-world crises** by analyzing contemporary geopolitical flashpoints and developing evidence-based policy recommendations.
- **Produce evidence-based written analysis** that synthesizes theory, empirical evidence, and case materials to address major security debates.

Content

Most of the questions that dominate geopolitics center on power and the causes of war and political violence. International trade and cooperation are critically important, but for most scholars of international relations and policymakers, international security issues around the onset and termination of political conflict and large-scale violence take pride of place.

This course surveys scholarly and policy literature on international relations (IR) theory, with a focus on international security as it has evolved in the past, the present, and as it might in the future to understand the play of geopolitics. The first part of the course introduces critical conceptual and theoretical scaffolding. For example, we will problematize the concept of “security,” explore the evolution of the state system from its Westphalian roots, through colonial impacts, and examine how the tools

states use to pursue security have changed over time. The second section will then turn to different types of warfare, including conventional, unconventional, and nuclear; as well as civil wars, or large-scale political violence that takes place within states, and terrorism. The third section turns to a series of topics on the future of security and war as a result of structural factors that might impact geopolitics, including demographics, technology and climate change.

Students will read canonical texts from IR theory and security fields, and debates on such issues as security, strategy, deterrence, polarity, and the role and effectiveness of international organizations on security cooperation and conflict. Students will be provided with an opportunity to critically engage IR theory and international security by assessing real word crises and together identifying new questions and approaches that might help address critical theoretical and policy challenges.

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

The course is offered as a blocked seminar over 3 days, with 2 thematic sessions per day (8 sessions in total). It is organized into three main parts:

1. Introduction to Security and the International System
2. Types of Warfare
3. Future Security and War: X Factors

Each part integrates readings, discussion, and applied analysis. Students engage with scholarly and policy literature, critically assess real-world crises, and participate in group work and presentations to deepen their understanding of contemporary and future security challenges.

This is a graduate-level course. Students are expected to come to class having completed the readings and prepared to discuss them. Understanding that you have other classes and commitments, I have tried to keep the required readings to a minimum. Nevertheless, there is a good amount of reading, some of which you should just peruse to absorb the main points and debates. Active participation is important and will be part of your grade. Moreover, you are expected to be fully engaged in group work and leveraging presentation opportunities to enhance presentation and speaking skills

Additionally, at the start of each class we will discuss historical and contemporary events as they appear in the news, so stay apprised of what is happening around the world and come to class prepared to raise critical issues and discuss them in an informed way (e.g. the war in Ukraine, the rise of the People's Republic of China, shifting alignments in Southwest Asia, migration flows, cyberattacks and breaches). Students are welcome to share interesting reads they encounter during their time in the course and we might ask the class to discuss those suggestions (and some of my own) formally in class from time to time.

Decorum: One great thing about this type of class is the exchange of ideas. The ideas we will be discussing influence policies and lives. Therefore, it is both fun and important that we engage with them. Unsurprisingly, some of you will have strong opinions. Some of you might just want to be contrarian. That is great. However, the purpose here is to learn. To keep the discussion collegial and polite, here are a few guidelines to follow:

- Be respectful.
- Keep discussions focused on ideas. We will not tolerate personal attacks.
- Do not make unsupported assertions. Use evidence from the course or current events to support your points.
- Listen when others speak—otherwise your responses will be ineffective.
- Keep your responses short and concise. We want everyone to have an opportunity to speak.

Literature

Readings include a mix of classic and contemporary scholarly articles, policy analyses, and selected multimedia sources. Students will engage with foundational IR theory, security studies literature, and contemporary case studies to develop critical thinking and evidence-based analysis skills.

Part I: Introduction to Security and the International System

Session 1: Introduction to Security and Power

Required Readings

1. Fukuyama, Frank. "The End of History?" *The National Interest* No. 16 (1989): 3-18.

2. Mearsheimer, John. "Back to the Future: Instability in Europe after the Cold War." *International Security* 15, No. 1 (Summer 1990): 5-56.
3. Allison, Graham. "The Thucydides Trap: Are the U.S. and China Headed for War? The Atlantic, 24 September 2015.
4. Toft, Monica Duffy. "The Return of Spheres of Influence: Will Negotiations Over Ukraine Be a New Yalta Conference That Carves Up the World?" Foreign Affairs, March 13, 2025.

Recommended Readings

1. Paris, Roland. "Human Security: Paradigm Shift or Hot Air?" *International Security* 26, No. 2 (Fall 2001): 87-102.
2. https://www.theatlantic.com/international/archive/2015/09/united-states-china-war-thucydides-trap/406756/.
3. Garrett, Laurie. "The Next Pandemic?" *Foreign Affairs* 84, No. 4 (2005): 3-23.

Session 2: Evolution of the State System and its Legacies

Required Readings

1. Jervis, Robert. "Cooperation Under the Security Dilemma." *World Politics* 30, No. 2 (1978): 167–214.
2. Finnemore, Martha and Kathryn Sikkink. "International Norm Dynamics and Political Change." *International Organization* 52, No. 4 (Autumn 1998): 887-917.
3. Walt, Stephen M. "International Relations: One World, Many Theories," *Foreign Policy* (Spring 1998): 29-–32, 34-–46.

Recommended Readings

1. Walt, Stephen M. "Alliance Formation and the Balance of World Power." *International Security* 9, No. 4 (Spring 1985): 3–43.
2. Vinjamuri, Leslie. "01 The Fracturing of the US-Led Liberal International Order." In Competing Visions of International Order, edited by Hans Kundnani and Leslie Vinjamuri, Chapter 1. London: Chatham House, March 2025.
3. Edward Said on Orientalism: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fVC8EYd_Z_g

Session 3: Violence and War

Required Readings

1. Kaplan, Robert. D. "The Coming Anarchy." *The Atlantic Monthly*, 2 February 1994.
2. Pinker, Steven. "Violence Vanquished." *Wall Street Journal*, 24 September 2011.
3. Fazal, Tanisha. "Dead Wrong?" *International Security* 39, No. 1 (Summer 2014): 95–125.
4. Watch: Halloran, Neil. *The Fallen of World War II*. 2015. Toros, Harmonie, Lee Jarvis, and Richard Jackson. "What the War on Terror Leaves Behind: An Introduction." European Journal of International Security 9, no. 2 (2024): 91–100. Cambridge University Press.

Recommended Readings

1. Caprioli, Mary. "Primed for Violence: The Role of Gender Inequality in Predicting Internal Conflict." *International Studies Quarterly* 49 No. 2 (2005): 161–78.
2. Hanlon, Querine H. "Globalization and the Transformation of Armed Groups." In *Armed Groups: Studies in National Security, Counter-terrorism, and Counterinsurgency*, Jeffrey Norwitz, ed., 137-47. Newport, RI: Naval War College Press, 2008.

Part II: Types of Warfare

Session 4: How to Fight Wars, Conventionally and Unconventionally

Required Readings

1. Art, Robert. "To What Ends Military Power?" *International Security* 4, No. 4 (Spring1980): 3-35.
2. Arreguín-Toft, Ivan. "How the Weak Win Wars: A Theory of Asymmetric Conflict." *International Security* 26, No. 1 (Summer 2001): 93--128.
3. Kilcullen, David. "Counter-insurgency Redux," *Survival* 48, No. 4 (2006): 111-30.

Recommended Readings

1. Hazelton, Jacqueline L. "The 'Hearts and Minds' Fallacy: Violence, Coercion, and Success in Counterinsurgency Warfare." International Security 42, No. 1 (Summer 2017): 80–113.
2. Slusher, Matthew N., et al. "Lessons from the Ukraine Conflict: Modern Warfare in the Age of Autonomy, Information, and Resilience." Report, Center for Strategic and International Studies, May 2025.
3. Jones, Seth G. "The Tech Revolution and Irregular Warfare: Leveraging Commercial Innovation for Great Power Competition." Policy Brief. Center for Strategic and International Studies, January 30, 2025.

Recommended to watch the opening sequence to Saving Private Ryan movie (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PmiphUYwL_0)

Session 5: Nuclear Security

Required Readings

1. Wohlstetter, Albert. "The Delicate Balance of Terror." *Foreign Affairs* 37, No. 2 (January 1959): 211-34.
2. Sagan, Scott. "The Perils of Proliferation: Organization Theory, Deterrence Theory, and the Spread of Nuclear Weapons." *International Security* 18 No. 4 (Spring 1994): 66-107.
3. Tannenwald, Nina. "How Strong Is the Nuclear Taboo Today?" *The Washington Quarterly* 41, No. 3 (Fall 2018): 89-109.

Recommended Readings

1. Waltz, Kenneth. "The Spread of Nuclear Weapons: More May Be Better." *Adelphi Papers* 21, No.171 (Autumn 1981): 1-32.
2. Cohn, Carol and Sara Ruddick. *A Feminist Ethical Perspective on Weapons of Mass Destruction*. Working Paper 104. Boston, MA: Consortium on Gender, Security and Human Rights, 2003.
3. O'Hanlon, Michael E. "How Unchecked AI Could Trigger a Nuclear War." Brookings Institution, 28 February 2025.

Recommended to watch Dr. Strangelove *movie*

Session 6: Civil wars, including Religion and Terrorism

Required Readings

1. Posen, Barry R. "The Security Dilemma and Ethnic Conflict." *Survival* 35, No. 1 (Spring 1993): 27-47.
2. Huntington, Samuel P. "The Clash of Civilizations?" *Foreign Affairs* 72, No. 3 (1993): 22-49.
3. Toft, Monica Duffy. "Ending Civil Wars: A Case for Rebel Victory." *International Security* 34, No. 4 (Spring 2010): 7-36.
4. Wood, Graeme. "What ISIS Really Wants," *The Atlantic* 315, No. 2 (March 2015): 78-94.

Recommended Readings

1. Mansfield, Edward and Jack Snyder. "Democratization and the Danger of War." *International Security* 20, No. 1 (Summer 1995): 5-38.
2. Howard, Lise M. and Alexandra Stark. 2018. "How Civil Wars End: The International System, Norms, and the Role of External Actors." *International Security* 42, No. 3 (Winter 2018): 127-71
3. Toft, Monica Duffy. "Getting Religion Right in Civil Wars." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* (March 2021).

Recommended to watch the film Battle of Algiers

Part III: Future Security and War: X Factors

Session 7: Demographics and Technology

Required Readings

1. Tuchman Matthews, Jessica. "Redefining Security." *Foreign Affairs* 68, No. 2 (Spring 1989): 162-77.
2. Hudson, Valerie M. and Andrea den Boer. "A Surplus of Men, A Deficit of Peace: Security and Sex Ratios in Asia's Largest States." *International Security* 26, No. 4 (Spring 2002): 5-38.
3. Toft, Monica Duffy. 2014. "Death by Demography: 1979 as a Turning Point in the Disintegration of the Soviet Union." *International Area Studies Review* 17(2), pp. 184204.
4. Molly Kinder, et al. *New Data Show No AI Jobs Apocalypse*—For Now, Brookings, October 2025.

Recommended Readings

1. Hudson, Valerie M., et al. 2009. "The Heart of the Matter: The Security of Women and the Security of States." *International Security* 33, No. 3 (Winter 2009): 7-45.
2. Inglehart, Ronald and Pippa Norris. "The True Clash of Civilizations." *Foreign Policy*, 4 November 2009.
3. Bloom, David, Matthew McKenna, and Klaus Prettner. 2018. "Demography, unemployment, and automation: Challenges in creating (decent) jobs until 2030." *Vox Europe*, December 17, 2018. https://voxeu.org/article/demography-unemployment-andautomation
4. Lu, Yao. "Political Demography: The Political Consequences of Structural Population Change," *Annual Review of Sociology (*August 2024)https://www.annualreviews.org/docserver/fulltext/soc/50/1/annurev-soc-030222-024414.pdf?expires=1764011571&id=id&accname=guest&checksum=220DD6CDF02751046714DA39BD7698FF

Session 8: The Environment and Climate Change

Required Readings

1. Gleick, Peter H. "Environment and Security: The Clear Connections," *Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists* 47, no. 3 (April 1991): 16.
2. Levy, Marc. "Is the Environment a National Security Issue?" *International Security*. Vol. 20, No. 2, Fall 1995, pp. 35–62.
3. Meyer, Robinson. "Does Climate Change Cause More War?" *The Atlantic*, 12 February 2018.
4. Christopher Flavelle et al., "Climate Change Poses a Widening Threat to National Security," *The New York Times*, October 21, 2021, sec. Climate, https://www.nytimes.com/2021/10/21/climate/climate-change-national-security.html

Recommended Readings

1. Mach, K.J., C.M. Kraan, W.N. Adger, et al. "Climate as a Risk Factor for Armed Conflict." *Nature* 571 (July 2019): 193–7.
2. IPCC Climate Report 2021: https://www.ipcc.ch/2021/08/09/ar6-wg1-20210809-pr/
3. Oslo (PRIO), Peace Pesearch Institute. n.d. "Trends and Triggers: Climate, Climate Change and Civil Conflict in Sub-Saharan Africa https://www.prio.org/Publications/Publication/?x=3708.

Additional information

Monica Duffy Toft is Professor of International Politics and Director of the Center for Strategic Studies at The Fletcher School of Law and Diplomacy. A former U.S. Army Russian linguist, she holds a Ph.D. from the University of Chicago and has taught at Oxford University and Harvard Kennedy School. Her research focuses on international security, civil wars, ethnic and religious violence, and the intersection of demography and national security. She is the author of several books, including *Securing the Peace*, *Political Demography*, and *God's Century*, and has published widely on conflict, territory, and global politics. She is also affiliated with Oxford, Harvard, and the Peace Research Institute Oslo, and is a member of the Council on Foreign Relations.

Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	35%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

Final Op-eds Paper

Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids

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2. Examination sub part (2/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Active participation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Synchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	25%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

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Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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3. Examination sub part (3/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	40%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Two Reading Response Memos

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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Content

Your grade will be based on the following four elements:

- 25% Participation
- 40% Two Reading response memos (500 words / each 20%)
- 35% Final op-eds paper (750 each / total 1500 words)

Participation (25%)

Participation is not the same thing as attendance. All students are expected to be actively engaged in the class meetings and with their peers in the group work throughout the course.

Reading Response Memos (40%)

Students are responsible for writing and submitting **two** critical response memos of no more than 500 words. At least one of these memos needs to be submitted for sessions 1–4 and another for sessions 5–8. The memos should respond to the readings and dynamics for a given session, but they should not summarize the readings: rather, the memos should demonstrate the students' critical thinking about the strengths and limitations of a set of readings and how they relate to the given issue of that

session. Reading response memos are due at the beginning of that session's class so you might want to read ahead and start thinking about which topics interest you.

Final Op-eds Paper (35%)

Students are to draft **two** op-eds—no more than 750 words each— on the same issue, with each op-ed taking opposing sides on the same issue. They are to be handed in at the same time. These op-eds papers are required to have citations or references appended at the end of the paper, with some selections drawn from the assigned course readings. These citations and references are not included in the word count. The format specifications for all papers are Times New Roman 12pt font, double spacing, one-inch margins.

Literature

All readings provided in the course are relevant for assignments and class discussion. Students are encouraged to explore additional sources if helpful for developing their op-eds or deepening their understanding of specific topics. All course materials will be available on Canvas.

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).